

Benefits Guide

=====

Purpose

Northwind Robotics offers benefits to support employee health, financial wellbeing, and long-term stability. This guide summarizes the main benefit options for eligible employees and the enrollment process. Plan documents and the annual enrollment materials contain the full terms and control if there is any conflict with this summary.

Eligibility

Benefits eligibility depends on employment classification and scheduled hours:

- Full-time employees working 30 or more hours per week are eligible for the full benefits package.
- Part-time employees working fewer than 30 hours per week are generally not eligible for medical, dental, and vision coverage, except where a state law requires an offer. They may still be eligible for the 401(k) plan once they meet the service requirement.
- Contractors, interns, and temporary workers are not eligible for the standard employee benefits package.

An employee's eligibility_status in the HR system is one of eligible, pending (in the waiting period or missing a required action), or ineligible.

When Coverage Starts

For a newly eligible employee, medical, dental, and vision coverage is effective the first day of the month after 30 days of employment. For example, an employee who starts on March 10 has coverage effective May 1. The employee must complete their elections in the benefits system before the deadline in their enrollment notice; missing the deadline delays coverage until the next open enrollment or a qualifying life event.

Open Enrollment

Open enrollment runs each November, with elections effective January 1 of the following year. This is the once-a-year window to add or drop coverage, change medical plans, or change dependents without a qualifying life event. Elections not changed during open enrollment generally roll over, except that FSA elections must be made new each year.

Qualifying Life Events

Outside open enrollment, an employee may change elections within 30 days of a qualifying life event, such as marriage or divorce, birth or adoption, a dependent gaining or losing other coverage, a change in the employee's employment status, or a move that changes plan availability. The employee must submit the change and the supporting documentation within the 30-day window.

Medical Plans

Two medical plans are offered:

- PPO ? higher premium, lower deductible, broad network, no referral needed for specialists.
- HDHP ? lower premium, higher deductible, paired with a Health Savings Account (HSA) the employee can fund with pre-tax dollars up to the IRS annual limit; the balance is the employee's to keep.

The company pays a set share of the premium for employee-only coverage and a smaller share for dependent tiers; the employee's share is deducted from each paycheck. Specific premiums, deductibles, and out-of-pocket maximums are in the annual enrollment materials.

Dental and Vision

Dental and vision coverage are optional and elected separately from medical. An employee may waive medical but still elect dental and/or vision if they are otherwise eligible.

401(k) Retirement Plan

Employees are eligible to contribute to the 401(k) plan after 90 days of employment. The company matches 100% of the first 4% of eligible pay the employee contributes; the match is immediately vested. Employees may contribute up to the IRS annual limit and may choose traditional pre-tax or Roth contributions. An employee who contributes less than 4% receives a smaller match; an employee who contributes more than 4% still receives only the 4% match but keeps the additional personal contribution.

Flexible Spending Account (FSA)

Eligible employees may elect a health-care FSA up to the IRS annual maximum (\$3,200 for the current plan year). FSA funds are pre-tax and must be used for eligible expenses within the plan year and any grace period; unused funds above the plan's small carryover limit are forfeited. FSA elections do not roll over and must be made each open enrollment.

Other Benefits

Eligible employees also have access to:

- an Employee Assistance Program (confidential counseling and referral support),
- company-paid basic life and disability coverage, with options to buy additional coverage,
- short-term disability at 60% of pay (see the Leave of Absence Policy),
- the professional development benefit (see the Performance and Development Policy),
- voluntary benefits offered from time to time during open enrollment.

Changes in Employment Status

A change in status can affect eligibility and effective dates ? for example moving between full-time and part-time, going on or returning from leave, converting from contractor to employee, or separation. Employees must notify People Operations promptly so coverage is updated correctly. On separation, coverage ends on the last day of the month of the separation date, and the employee receives information about continuation options where available.

Getting Help

Questions about plan choice, premiums, deductibles, coverage rules, or enrollment deadlines go to People Operations or the benefits administrator. Decision-support tools and summaries are provided during open enrollment.

Related Policies

- Leave of Absence Policy
- Parental and Family Leave Policy
- Compensation and Payroll Policy
- Performance and Development Policy
- PTO and Vacation Policy

Summary

Full-time employees working 30+ hours a week are eligible; coverage starts the first of the month after 30 days. Open enrollment is each November for a January 1 effective date, and life events allow changes within 30 days. Medical is PPO or HDHP (HDHP with an HSA); dental and vision are optional. The 401(k) is available after 90 days with an immediately vested match of 100% of the first 4% of pay. The health FSA maximum is the IRS limit, \$3,200 for the current plan year.